

intelligent, deeply serious young man, fluent in several languages and acutely conscious of his duties as the unofficial king of England. But it was his looks as much as his character, and his recommendation by Victoria's uncle, Leopold I of Belgium, that persuaded her to propose to this "perfect being." She was drawn to his appearance, adoring his "exquisite nose" and "beautiful figure," which she described as "broad in the shoulders."

Love and marriage

Victoria and Albert presented the public with the novel spectacle of a young and serenely happy royal family. In the space of 17 years, they had nine children: four sons and five daughters. The birth of the Princess Royal ("Vicky") in 1840 was followed, a year later, by the birth of a son and heir, the future Edward VII. For the birth of her eighth baby, Prince Leopold, Victoria had pain relief in the shape of newly available chloroform. She found it "soothing, quieting and delightful beyond measure," and this royal endorsement made it easier for other women to opt for pain relief in childbirth.

To reach their new homes at Balmoral in Scotland and Osborne on the Isle of Wight, the royal family took advantage of the railroads, another recent invention. For Victoria, Balmoral Castle, with its specially designed turrets and tartans, was a

End of an era

The funeral procession of Queen Victoria, February 1901. She was laid to rest in the Frogmore mausoleum at Windsor Castle, alongside Albert.



Exhibiting the world

Victoria arrives for the opening of the Great Exhibition "of the works of industry of all nations" at the Crystal Palace in London's Hyde Park.

First Boer War

This jug, bearing Victoria's image, commemorates the First Boer War, 1880–81, in which Transvaal Boers resisted British efforts to annex South Africa, winning self-governance under nominal British oversight.



"dear paradise" and "... Albert's own creation, own work, own building, own laying-out." Her beloved husband's interest in art and design culminated in the Great Exhibition of 1851, for which 112,000 items from across the world were displayed in the Crystal Palace, a glass and iron exhibition hall in Hyde Park, London, of roughly 21 acres (85,000 m²).



Victoria Cross

This military decoration for conspicuous bravery was created by Queen Victoria in 1856.

The widow of Windsor

Albert's sudden death from typhoid in 1861 was a shock from which Victoria never fully recovered. As the "widow of Windsor," she withdrew from public life and lost some of her early popularity. But time was on her side. Partly as a result of Albert's steadying influence, she had removed herself from direct involvement in political conflicts, so that the Crown eventually came to be seen as above party politics, a neutral guarantee of constitutional stability.

Even so, Victoria had strong personal opinions on the major issues and

personalities of the day. She disliked the great Liberal leader, William Ewart Gladstone, because he spoke to her as if she were "a public meeting." She had a much better relationship with his rival, Benjamin Disraeli, who coaxed and flattered the widowed queen into renewing her interest and participation in public life. It was Disraeli who had Victoria proclaimed Empress of India, a title and a role in which she took great interest and pride.

By 1887, the year in which she celebrated her Golden Jubilee, the 50th anniversary of her reign, Victoria had regained her early popularity. Ten years later, on the occasion of the Diamond Jubilee of 1897, the queen-empress commanded global esteem and affection. The spectacular celebrations in London were attended by representatives of her 387 million subjects around the world. Soon afterward, her health began to fail, and she was 81 when she died in January 1901. By that time, she was related to so many royal families that she was popularly known as the "grandmother of Europe".



"We are not amused."

QUEEN VICTORIA, ATTRIBUTED, 1900

TIMELINE

- **May 24, 1819** Alexandrina Victoria is born at Kensington Palace, London.
- **June 26, 1830** William IV becomes King of the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Ireland, and with no legitimate children to succeed him, his niece Victoria becomes heiress presumptive.
- **1830** The Regency Act of 1830 assures that Victoria cannot become queen until she is 18.
- **May 24, 1837** Turns 18 and becomes eligible to assume the throne should her uncle die.
- **June 20, 1837** Becomes Queen of the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Ireland when William IV dies of heart failure.
- **June 28, 1838** Coronation ceremony at Westminster Abbey, London.
- **February 10, 1840** Marries her cousin Prince Albert of Saxe-Coburg-Gotha in the Chapel Royal at St. James's Palace, London.
- **May 6, 1840** England issues its first postage stamp, costing one penny, which bears the image of Queen Victoria.
- **June 10, 1840** The first of a total of seven attempts on her life is made when Edward Oxford fires two bullets into her coach—she is pregnant at the time.
- **November 21, 1840** Her first child, the Princess Royal Victoria Adelaide Mary, is born. Victoria and Albert will have a further eight children.
- **May 1851** Victoria opens the Great Exhibition in Hyde Park, London, which showcases international culture and industry.
- **1853** Chloroform administered to Queen Victoria in childbirth.
- **1855** Livingstone names the Victoria Falls on Africa's Zambezi River after the Queen.
- **1856** Balmoral Castle is completed.
- **June 26, 1857** Victoria Cross awarded for the first time; 62 soldiers and sailors receive it.
- **December 14, 1861** Devastated by the death of Albert, Victoria sinks into depression and starts a period of isolation, withdrawing from public life.
- **May 1, 1876** Proclaimed the "Empress of India" by the British Prime Minister Benjamin Disraeli.
- **1887** Golden Jubilee marks her 50th year as monarch. The celebrations help to draw Victoria back into public life.
- **September 22, 1896** Victoria's reign surpasses that of George III as the longest in English, Scottish, and British history.
- **1897** Diamond Jubilee is celebrated with a procession to St. Paul's Cathedral in London, and a thanksgiving mass.
- **January 22, 1901** Dies of a cerebral hemorrhage at Osborne House on the Isle of Wight, bringing to an end a reign of nearly 64 years.



SHILLING SHOWING QUEEN VICTORIA